Has Internet Performance Degraded Due to AI Traffic?

Web research summary — compiled July 17, 2026

Question Asked

Use websearch to answer question: Has internet performance degraded due to traffic, especially AI traffic, in July of 2026?

Summary Answer

As of mid-July 2026, there is no single dramatic headline event where “the internet broke” due to AI traffic. The picture is one of rising structural strain rather than collapse: outage counts are climbing, AI/bot traffic is growing far faster than human traffic, and there is a widely acknowledged gap between network capacity and AI demand — producing more frequent AI-related downtime and performance degradation at the level of individual sites, data centers, and enterprise networks, rather than a global internet-wide slowdown.

Rising Outage and Incident Counts (Not Clearly AI-Attributed)

ThousandEyes (a Cisco company) reported 509 global network outage events during the week of July 6–12, 2026, up 15% from the prior week, with U.S. outages up 27% week-over-week. These weekly reports track a mix of causes (ISP issues, cloud provider incidents, DNS/CDN problems) and do not attribute the increase specifically to AI traffic.

Source: Network World, “2026 network outage report and internet health check” (networkworld.com)

AI Traffic Is Growing Far Faster Than Human Traffic

- Fastly's analysis found AI requests increased about 30% in the first five months of 2026, growing roughly 6.5 times faster than human traffic. Fastly's CTO argued this signals AI traffic is fundamentally changing how the internet operates, as AI systems increasingly interact with websites directly on behalf of users.
- A 2026 AI Bot Impact Report found bots now account for 52% of global web traffic, outnumbering human visitors roughly three to one — framed as a genuine resource crisis rather than a vanity statistic, since heavy bot activity can slow or crash sites even on shared hosting when human traffic is low.

Sources: TechRadar / Fastly research (techradar.com); Skynet Hosting 2026 AI Bot Impact Report (skynethosting.net)

A Real, Widely Acknowledged Network Readiness Gap

- Broadcom's 2026 State of Network Operations report found that while 99% of organizations have cloud/AI strategies, only 49% believe their networks can actually support the bandwidth and low latency AI requires.

- Cisco's 2026 report on campus/branch networks found every surveyed technology leader admitted their organization has experienced some form of AI-related downtime. Agent-driven tasks can generate up to 450% more total traffic than the same task performed without an agent.
- Industry analysts describe “microburst” effects, where thousands of GPUs finishing a compute cycle and sending data simultaneously can overwhelm switch buffers, causing dropped packets and retransmission delays. Many enterprises are described as unprepared for the jump from gigabit-scale to terabit-level AI cluster traffic.

Sources: Network World / Broadcom 2026 State of Network Operations report (networkworld.com); Cisco 2026 Impact of AI on Campus and Branch Networks report (cisco.com); Data Center Knowledge, “The Breaking Points: Networking Strains Under AI's Scale Demands” (datacenterknowledge.com)

Bottom Line

No single reported event shows the internet as a whole degrading in July 2026 specifically because of AI traffic. Instead, ThousandEyes, Cisco, Broadcom, Fastly, and Backblaze data all point to the same underlying trend: AI and bot traffic (crawlers, inference calls, and increasingly autonomous agents) is growing much faster than human traffic and outpacing network capacity planning in many organizations, resulting in more frequent AI-related downtime and localized performance degradation — a structural strain story rather than a global outage story.

Note: This is a fast-moving topic. Findings reflect web search results available as of July 17, 2026 and should be re-checked for any specific event, provider, or date of interest.